

The Treatise on the Resurrection

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Editor's Introduction

Introduced and translated by Malcolm L. Peel

The importance of this short, eight-page, didactic letter lies in its witness to a distinctively unorthodox interpretation of Christian teaching about survival after death. By the late second century, the probable time of its composition, Christians—whether Gnostic or orthodox—were struggling with certain challenges and questions. Was such survival philosophically demonstrable (as Socrates had argued in the *Phaedo*)? What form might it take? (Immortality of the soul? Resurrection of the body? Reincarnation?) When would such survival be experienced? (At death? At Christ's final return? Perhaps even before death?) The New Testament teaching was somewhat ambiguous on several of these points, though within the great church there seemed general agreement on at least two matters: the prototype and basis of hope for such survival was the resurrection of Jesus Christ, and the resurrection of individuals would entail their retention of personal identity.

The anonymous author of *The Treatise on the Resurrection*, however, claimed a Christ-given knowledge (49,41-50,2) that enabled him to offer direct and unambiguous answers to such questions, questions which in this case had been put to him by his pupil, Rheginos (43,25). First, the resurrection is a matter of faith in the reality of Jesus Christ's resurrection and his destruction of death (46,14-19). Such cannot be the result of philosophical "persuasion," and most philosophers of the world are in fact sceptics.

Second, the form of survival will be the "resurrection," which is not understood as the re-creation of a spiritual body at Christ's Parousia (cf. 1 Co 15 passim). Rather, at the point of biological death, the "elect" believer experiences the separation of the inward, "living members," whose intellectual nature is clarified by reference to the "mind" and its "thought," from the external "body" of "perishable," "visible," outward "members" (47,38-48,2; 45,39-46,2; 45,19-21). Even so, this "resurrection body," covered with a new "flesh" (47,4-8) or "garment of light" ("rays" in 45,30-31), retains personally identifiable features, as the appearance of Elijah and Moses at Christ's transfiguration (Mk 9:2-8) makes clear. Such is the "spiritual resurrection" which "swallows up" (i.e., renders nonsensical or destroys) the "resurrection" of either the naked "soul" or of the crudely literal "flesh" (45,39-46,2). Implied is a dualistic doctrine of outer/inner that goes beyond Pauline anthropology.

Third, unlike the early church, which in its resurrection hope held to an "eschatological reservation" (i.e., the notion that the full benefit of individual Christians' participation in the resurrection would wait the final return of Christ), the author of *The Treatise on the Resurrection* held that for the elect believer who had proleptically participated in Christ's suffering (death), resurrection, and ascension (45,24-28), the new reality should be clear: one already has the resurrec-

tion in the present. In sum, our author, like the Hymenaeus and Philetus condemned in 2 Timothy 2:18, teaches that the resurrection has already occurred! He reinforces it by means of a kind of existential proof: the believer who knows of death's inevitability should consider himself as dead already and thus as already participating in the resurrected state (49,16-30). Thus, the believer is to have "faith" in the reality of Christ's victory over death and its guarantee (45,14-46, 4,14-17; 46,8-13), to avoid all "doubt" (47,36-48,3), to "know" the "Son of Man" and the truth proclaimed about his resurrection (46,13-17, 30-32), to "practise" one's release from the inimical power of this cosmos (49,30-33) through correct thought, and to realize the mystical unity between the experience of the Savior and that of the believer (45,15-46,2).

Major studies of the text have clarified that the author is a Christian Gnostic teacher who is clearly influenced by Valentinian Gnosticism. The evidence for this is found in the close parallels between the treatise's teaching that the spiritual resurrection has already occurred and the reports of Valentinian "realized eschatology" in Tertullian (*De praes. haer.* 33.7; *De res. mort.* 19,2-7) and Irenaeus (*Haer.* 2.31.2). Also, certain conceptual complexes unique to Valentinianism appear in *Treat. Res.*, such as the idea of a primordial pleroma which suffered a devolution and resulting "deficiency" (46,35-47,1; 49,4-5) which the Savior must "restore" (44,30-33).

Only to be expected, then, is the presence of Middle Platonic ideas which, as prior scholarship has shown, influenced Valentinianism. Such ideas include a distinction between a world of being (including the Good itself) and the sphere of becoming and corruption (48,20-27), as well as between an "intelligible world" and a "sensible" world (46,35-47,1). Also Platonic are notions of the pre-existence of souls (46,38-47,1; cf. 47,4-6; 49,30-36) and of "practising" for dying (49,28-33).

Rather un-Platonic, however, is the absence of any mention of an ultimate quest for ecstatic vision/union with the ultimate One, as well as our treatise's stress on retention of identifiable personal characteristics in the post mortem resurrected state.

Because of the centrality of Jesus Christ in the text, however, and because the author appeals to the New Testament as highest authority for his proofs (cf. 43,34; 45,4, 24-28; 48,6-11), we conclude that the author is a Christian Gnostic whose thought displays the influence of Middle Platonism as filtered through a late and somewhat vaguely articulated Valentinian Gnosticism.

Critical opinion now generally holds that *Treat. Res.* is not written by Valentinus himself. Studies of the stage of the New Testament canon of which the anonymous author seems aware, of the place of *Treat. Res.* teaching in the context of debates over the resurrection in the early church, and of the type of Middle Platonic ideas found in it all converge in pointing toward the late second century as the probable time of composition. As to its provenance, neither internal nor external evidence provides any clues.

Debate continues over whether the writing is a genuine didactic letter lacking a *praescriptio* naming its author (such as are the *Epistula Apostolorum* or the *Letter of Ptolemy to Flora*) and incorporating elements of the diatribe style, or whether it is principally a philosophical discourse decisively shaped by the Cynic-Stoic diatribe. As yet, the last named is lacking a convincing demonstration.

Most scholars do seem to reject the suggestions, however, that the text is the result of combining two originally separate letters or that it is the result of a gnostic redaction of an originally Christian text.